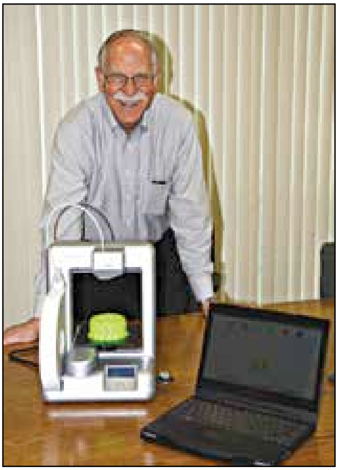
So how did this all begin?

Back in the mid 80s, Charles Hull was getting annoyed by the amount of time it took for him to make prototypes of his designs. While the original work flow involved the design being sent to a tool maker who would make the design in a material of your choice, he or she would seldom get it right the first time.

Since he was working with UV curable materials, he decided to develop a printer that would fire a beam of UV light in to a bath of UV curable resin and voila, he had three dimensionally printed a cup.



The father of 3D printing, Charles Hull

Now, to fully understand the why this was revolutionary, we have to understand that back in the day, virtually every manufacturing company, from the field of automobile engineering to manufacturers of die-cast materials, spent more money developing the product than actually manufacturing it.

With this need addressed, Charles Hull set up the 3D Systems Corp. and rewrote the rulebook on how new products are developed. Now, 30 years since, 3D printing has not only changed the way manufactures plan their product launches, due to the expiry of key patents, the sudden surge in the number of start-ups providing low cost DIY kits for hobbyists and enthusiasts has driven the popularity up and the 3D printer could one day be as commonplace as a USB thumb drive.

While Charles Hull's Stereolithographic 3D printing is only one style of printing there more. A popular style which was additive printing in the truest sense was developed in 1988 by S. Scott Crump who called it Fused Deposition Modelling. Here, the 3D printer would extrude layer after layer of molten plastic to produce an object. When the patent for FDM expired in 2007, it sparked the revolution in 3D printing leading to several start ups developing open source models and DIY kits adding 3D printing to the average geek's list of hobbies.

A year before that, in 1987 Drs. Carl Deckard and Joe Beaman developed yet another style known as Selective Laser Sintering (SLS). Here a laser